

MANFRED VON RICHTHOFEN ("THE RED BARON")

AN OFFICER IN THE GERMAN CAVALRY when the war started, Baron Manfred von Richthofen (1892–1918) transferred to the air service in 1915. Having flown as an observer and bomber pilot on the Eastern Front, he was chosen by Oswald Boelcke to join his elite fighter group in France. He soon proved himself to be one of Boelcke's ablest pupils, and the deaths of Boelcke and Max Immelmann in 1916 cleared the way for Richthofen's emergence as Germany's most prominent ace. He was given command of his own squadron, Jasta 11, and then of the first

Jagdgeschwader, grouping four squadrons in a fighter wing of about 50 aircraft. With its garishly colored machines, this was the



THE HIGHEST ACE

In 1917 the Red Baron painted his planes red to mark him out to friend and foe alike.

He was a ruthless hunter and, with 80 kills, achieved the highest tally of the war.

formation the British christened Richthofen's Flying Circus. Richthofen was a fine leader of men, but lacked personal warmth. His closest relationship was with his wolfhound, Moritz. Arrogant and ruthless, he showed few signs of chivalry or respect for his enemies – he was known to especially despise the French. Where many pilots used sport as a metaphor for air combat, Richthofen saw it in terms of hunting – his favorite leisure activity. He once wrote: "When I have shot down an Englishman my hunting passion is satisfied for a quarter of an hour."

On leave from the front, Richthofen was a celebrity, pursued by photographers and journalists, and dining with the Kaiser.

He even took time out to write

CLOSING IN

One of von Richthofen's hunting strategies was to let fly a short burst of fire while still far away from his target: "I did not mean so much to hit him as to frighten him... He began flying curves and this allowed me to draw near."

his memoirs. Having survived a headwound during a dogfight in July 1917, Richthofen came under pressure from his superiors to withdraw from combat. It was felt that his death would be a severe blow to morale. However, during the 1918 spring offensive he headed back into the fray. On April 21 he was shot through the heart while pursuing a potential victim over enemy lines. Whether the fatal shot was fired by an Australian machine-gunner or by Canadian pilot Roy Brown is still a matter of dispute.



HONOURED DEATH

On April 21, 1918 Baron von Richthofen was shot down over a sector of the front manned by Australian troops.

The Commonwealth troops buried the famous enemy with full military honors.

BARON'S MOUNT

Although it is the highly maneuverable "blood-red" Fokker Dr.I triplane with which Richthofen is associated, he spent most of his time flying biplanes like the Albatros D.II (right) and D.III.

